

First Read

Hong Kong Property

Slowing momentum in April retail sales

Equities

Hong Kong
Real Estate

April retail sales up 9% YoY, in-line with UBSe

The Hong Kong government released April retail sales figures today. Overall retail sales rose 9% YoY, compared with +13% YoY in March and +12% in 2M26, in line with our expectation of high-single-digit growth. Similar to March, key growth drivers remained: i) strong gold price performance; ii) continued robust demand for new iPhones; and iii) delayed delivery of electric vehicles following the expiration of the first registration tax exemption at end-March. However, all three key categories have seen a moderation in growth. Excluding consumer electronics (+22% YoY in April) and motor vehicles and parts (+46% YoY in April), April retail sales growth would have slowed to 6% YoY, compared with +8% YoY in March and +9% in 2M26, implying a marginal deceleration in underlying demand.

Excluding price effects, luxury sales volume up 6.5% YoY

By segment, luxury goods growth slowed to 20% YoY in April, compared with +28% YoY in March. However, after adjusting for price effects, luxury sales volume remained broadly stable at 6.5% YoY versus +6.4% YoY in March, indicating stabilisation in volume growth. On the staples side, food beverage sales were flat YoY in April, compared with +1% YoY growth in March, while supermarkets returned to 3% YoY growth after remaining broadly flat in March. Online retail sales growth moderated slightly to 31% YoY in April, compared with +35% YoY in March. As headline retail sales slowed, online penetration remained stable at 10% MoM.

May retail sales growth likely at mid to high single digit

Looking ahead to May 2026, we expect retail sales growth to come in at mid- to high-single digits, supported by several factors. First, both mainland and overseas visitor arrivals recorded growth of 12% and 3% YoY, respectively, in April, compared with +10% and +8% in March. The slowdown in overseas visitors could be linked to recent increases in airfares following the Middle East conflict. Second, weaker gold prices sequentially may continue to weigh on luxury spending growth. Outbound travel to the mainland remained largely stable at +10% YoY in April, compared with +9% in March, while overseas outbound travel narrowed to a 1% decline, versus a 12% decline in March. This should provide some support to local consumption.

Stock views:

We believe the slowing momentum in luxury goods in April 2026 has negative read-across for discretionary-focused retail landlords such as WREIC and Hysan. Meanwhile, the slight pickup in supermarket sales could act as a positive catalyst for Link REIT.

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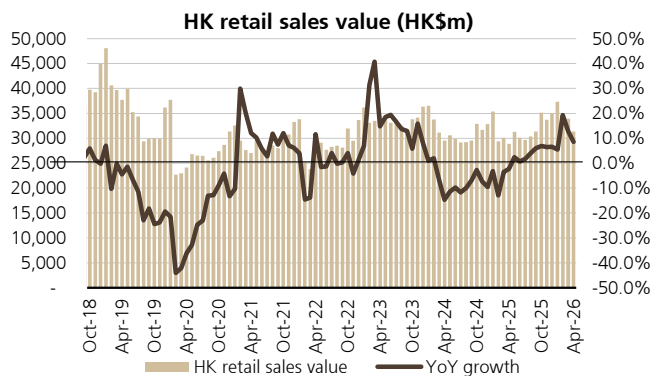
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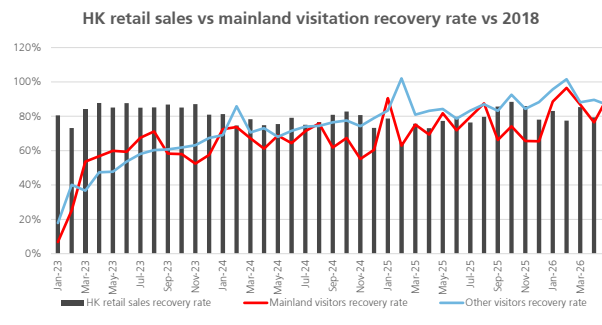
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Figure 1: Hong Kong's retail sales rose by 9% YoY in Apr, in-line with our forecast of high single digit increase



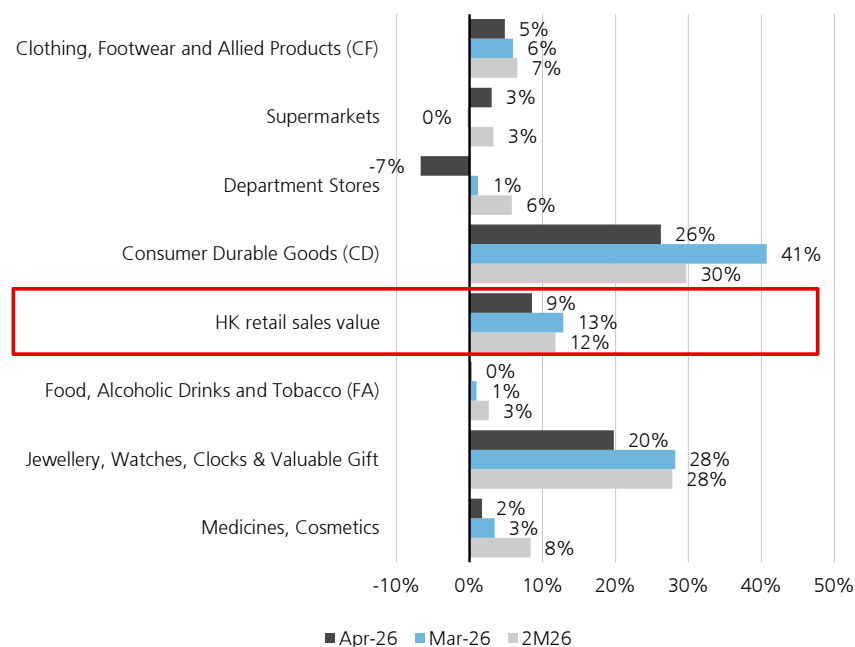
Source: CEIC

Figure 2: The April retail sales recovery rate reached 79% (vs 2018)



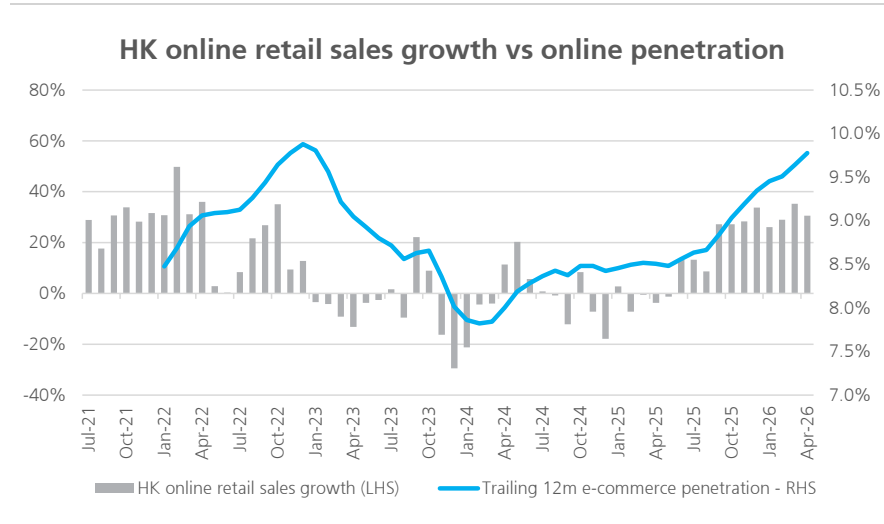
Source: CEIC

Figure 3: Electrical goods, luxury goods and EV sales continued to drive the retail sales growth in Apr



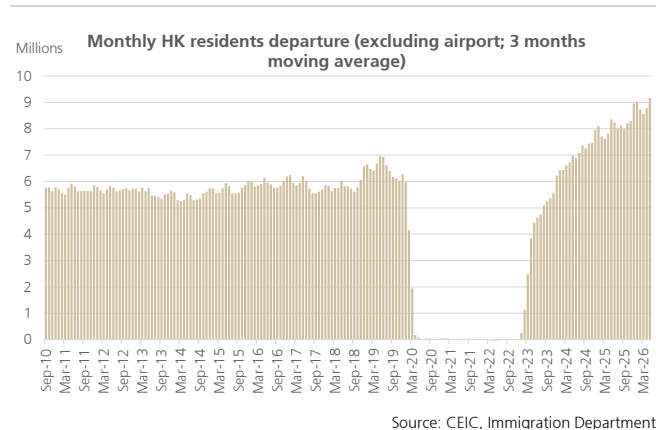
Source: CEIC

Figure 4: Online penetration remained at 10% in Apr 2026



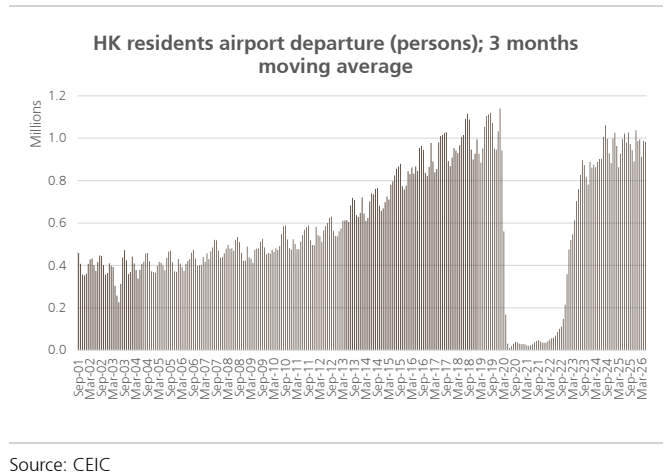
Source: CEIC

Figure 5: Monthly HK residents' northbound departures have recently stabilized at +10% in May



Source: CEIC

Figure 6: Overseas departure volumes by HK residents was slightly down 1% in May



Source: CEIC

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

We believe the key risks related to the Hong Kong property sector include: 1) weakening macroeconomic conditions; 2) a gradual increase in new housing supply; 3) higher-than-expected US Fed rate hikes.

Hysan: Our NAV-based valuation for Hysan is derived from a methodology of yield capitalisation on its investment property portfolio. Hysan has high exposure to Hong Kong office/retail properties. Therefore, our estimates depend on the performance of the Hong Kong commercial leasing market. We believe government policies, mortgage rate hikes, new supply, and global economic outlook are the main risks to the Hong Kong property market. We believe key downside risks to the Hong Kong office market include the level of social unrest, business confidence, and Chinese corporate office demand. For retail, we believe the uncertain political environment, a lack of central government policy support, and narrowing price differentials between Hong Kong and China are the key downside risks.

Link REIT: We derive our price target from a dividend discount model. Link REIT's ability to raise rent depends heavily on tenants' profitability, which relies on domestic macroeconomic conditions, especially factors that affect consumer spending in Hong Kong. Upside risk on further lower US 10-yr treasury yield and weakening HKD against USD. Downside risk on US 10-yr treasury yield further increases, outbound consumption leakage further picks up due to remained strong HKD, significantly delayed launch schedule for REIT connect.

Wharf REIC: We derive our price target from a dividend discount model. The performance of Wharf REIC's two flagship shopping centres in Hong Kong (Harbour City and Times Square) depends on the inflow of mainland Chinese shoppers and local economic conditions. Key downside risks include a slower-than-expected tourist spending recovery, fast growing onshore duty-free sales and the potential downgrade of Times Square. Upside risks include a stronger-than-expected recovery in tourist spending in Hong Kong and Macau due to the ongoing closure of international borders to Chinese tourists, which would result in Hong Kong and Macau becoming the only outbound travel destinations for Chinese tourists.

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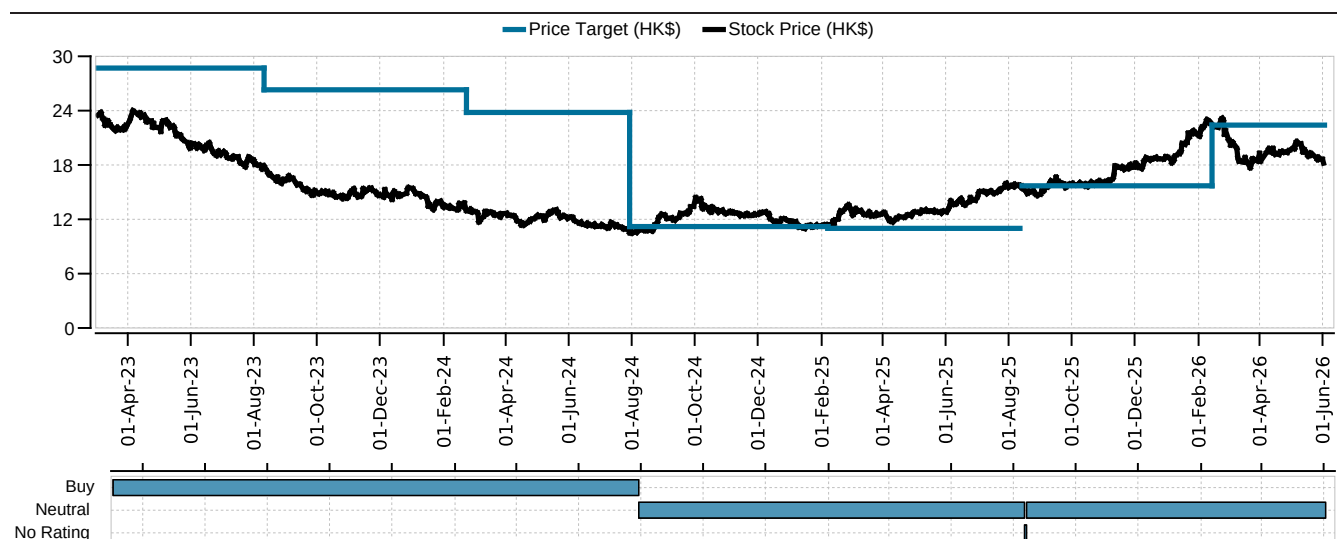
Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Hysan Development ^{4,5,6,28}	0014.HK	Neutral	HK\$18.20	02 Jun 2026
Link Real Estate Investment Trust ¹⁶	0823.HK	Buy	HK\$39.22	02 Jun 2026
Wharf Real Estate Investment ²⁸	1997.HK	Neutral	HK\$24.10	02 Jun 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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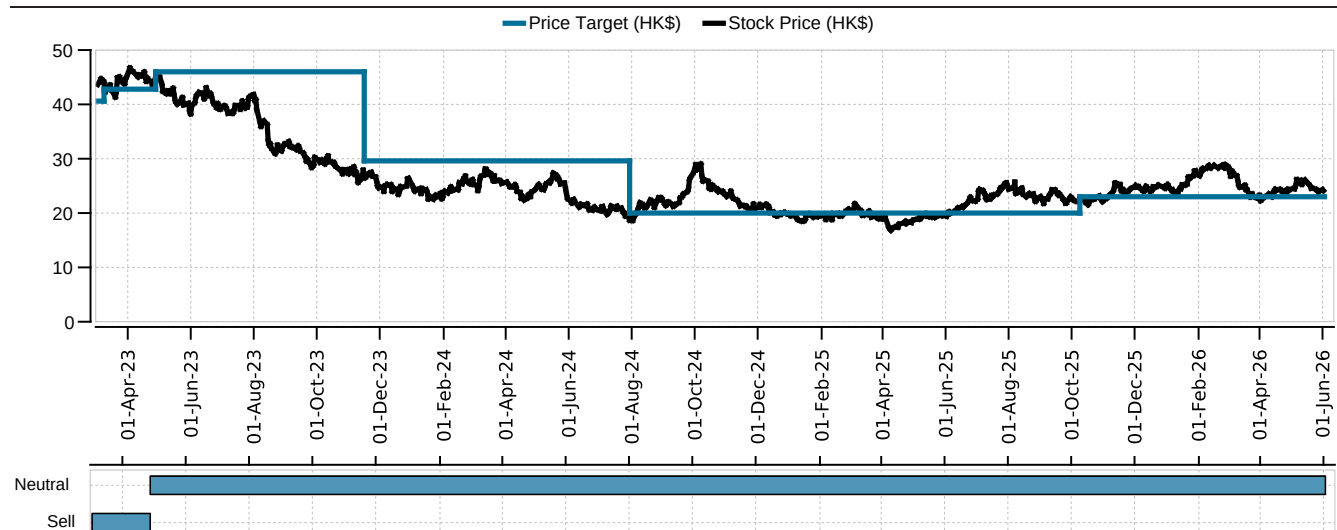
Hysan Development (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-03-02	23.00	28.70	Buy
2023-08-10	17.78	26.30	Buy
2024-02-22	13.24	23.80	Buy
2024-07-29	10.94	11.20	Neutral
2025-02-06	11.40	11.00	Neutral
2025-08-11	15.77	-	No Rating
2025-08-13	15.53	15.70	Neutral
2026-02-13	22.62	22.40	Neutral

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 02-Jun-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

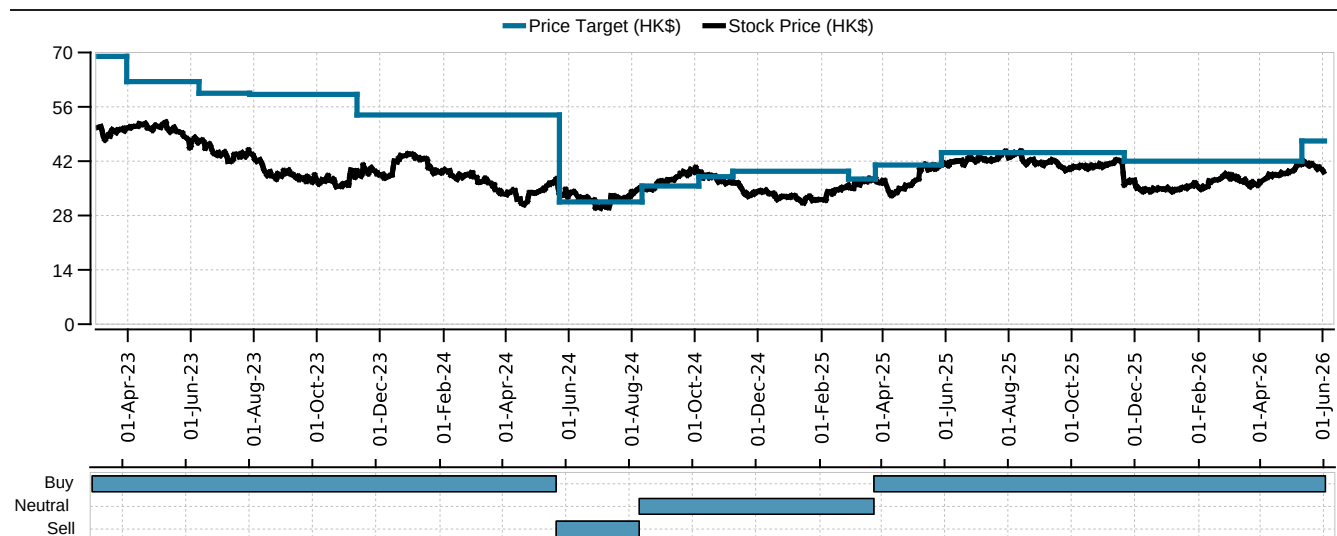
Wharf Real Estate Investment (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-03-02	43.45	40.60	Sell
2023-03-08	44.40	42.80	Sell
2023-04-27	44.15	46.00	Neutral
2023-11-15	27.90	29.60	Neutral
2024-07-29	19.24	20.00	Neutral
2025-10-08	22.20	23.00	Neutral

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 02-Jun-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

Link Real Estate Investment Trust (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-03-02	51.15	68.998	Buy
2023-03-30	50.40	62.50	Buy
2023-06-08	46.80	59.50	Buy
2023-07-27	44.85	59.20	Buy
2023-11-08	38.40	53.90	Buy
2024-05-22	34.75	31.50	Sell
2024-08-10	35.05	35.60	Neutral
2024-10-04	39.45	38.00	Neutral
2024-11-06	38.05	39.40	Neutral
2025-02-26	35.65	37.40	Neutral

Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2025-03-24	37.25	41.00	Buy
2025-05-27	40.90	44.20	Buy
2025-11-20	38.80	42.00	Buy
2026-05-11	41.18	47.20	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 02-Jun-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

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